

Listen to the Voices

The Best of Hill Fire

Charles Boebel
July 2007
Long Version

(After the opening music – perhaps “Reunion” or some other song from previous plays or a new song composed for this occasion – all except Roy exit or take their places in the auditorium)

SIR ROY

ROY

Hey, where did everybody go? They just up and left me. O well, I’m just glad to be out in the fresh air.

Can you believe I spent the last two years on a shelf, cooped up in a play book. It was called Last Train to Glory. I don’t like to brag, but I was the star of that show. Remember me? I’m Roy.

O, man. It feels so good to be out, I’m gonna enjoy myself all day. And know what else? It’s my birthday. Man O man.

(Kate enters on the balcony in her nurse’s ~~at~~ uniform.)

KATE

Roy! You’re late for work!

ROY

O, no. Are you out too?

KATE

I just got off my shift. I’m gonna run some errands and then get some sleep. You should have been at Garner’s station half an hour ago. You’re gonna get fired before you ever get started. Now go!

ROY

I’m going, I’m going. Yackity-yack, don’t talk back.

(Kate exits. Roy crosses to Garner’s station, where he meets Barksdale, Bob and Jimmy.)

BARKSDALE

Morning, Roy.

ROY

Morning, Barksdale. Sorry I'm late.

BARKSDALE

Didn't your alarm go off? You know you should get a clock that will scare the daylights into you.

JIMMY

It's a sad thing when the loafers get here before the help.

JOE

Yeah, who we gonna pick on?

BARKSDALE

Say, Roy, did you wash the Briscoe's car yesterday?

ROY

Reckon I did.

BARKSDALE

They brought it back this morning with soap streaks all over it. Appears you're like a lot of other folks I know. You like to have a job, but you don't like to work.

ROY

I'm sorry. I'll do it over.

BARKSDALE

It's already done. Did it myself. And here's another thing. You filled Putt Crull's crankcase with transmission fluid instead of motor oil.

ROY

O, man ...

BARKSDALE

You know, I've been thinking about letting you go. But I'd rather mend fences than break them. So I'm gonna put you in charge of a special project.

ROY

I'll do anything. If I lose this job, Kate will kill me.

JIMMY

And you would deserve to die ..

JOE

For being an idiot.

BARKSDALE

Roy, kneel down. You are herewith, through the authority invested in me by all of the powers of memory and mischief, charged with heading up the Gulf Oil Entertainment Commission, Winona Chapter. Your job is to sit yourself down and remember funny stories about our community and tell them to other folks or get other folks to tell them to us.

ROY

You're kidding.

BARKSDALE

No, sir, funny stories are much too serious to kid about. They're mostly about us.

And you're the most qualified man for the job. You have been idle for so long and have hung out with so many shiftless, no-good, loafers in so many different places around this town there's no man comes close to you. Arise, Sir Roy.

ALL

Arise, Sir Roy.

ROY

Well, thanks. I'm honored. I'm humbled. I don't know what to say.

BARKSDALE

Forget it. Just sit down, get comfortable, and get to work.

ROY

All right, I will. Was Putt mad about his car?

BARKSDALE

No sir. He told me a joke about lawyers. Seems an old fellow was nearing his end, and he sent for his lawyer and his banker. Said he wanted to be like Christ and die between two thieves.

ROY

Well, if Putt wasn't mad, let's start with a story about Putt. Let's do the one about the truckloads of shrimp.

JIMMY

Why, I was in on that joke I'll tell that story myself.

THREE TRUCKLOADS OF SHRIMP

JIMMY

Putt's a good lawyer. No doubt about that. And a good prosecutor. There's many a crook cooling his heels on account of Putt's zeal and hard work. But like a lot of other bachelors his age, he's got a weakness for partying, and he likes to indulge in various potations and concoctions that ain't good for him. When he wants to do that, he heads south. So as not to give the court a bad name.

(Enter Madelane.)

Now his sister Madelane had come for a visit, and Madelane is a most businesslike lady. To her, Putt is just a bad little brother.

MADELANE

Putt, I don't approve of your so-called junkets to New Orleans. I don't believe they're business trips at all. I think you go down there to indulge your bad habits. You have plenty to do around here. The garden is full of weeds, the windows need washing, and Lord knows, the vines are choking the house.

JIMMY

Now we knew where Putt had gone and why. And we knew Madelane did not approve. So we got the idea of calling Madelane and telling her that Putt had ordered three huge truckloads of shrimp to be delivered to the house.

(The telephone rings. Madelane picks up. Jimmy puts on a Cajun accent.)

MADELANE

Hello.

JIMMY

Ma'am, would this be the Putt Crull residence?

MADELANE

Yes. Who is this?

JIMMY

Ma'am, my name is Forest Bubba Boudreau of the Lafayette Louisiana Shrimp and Gumbo Company, and I have an order here to deliver three truckloads of shrimp to Mr. Crull's residence in Winona, Mississippi. I'm a stranger round here. Wonder if you could give me directions.

MADELANE

Three truckloads of shrimp! Three truckloads!

JIMMY

Yes, ma'am. Three truckloads of frozen shrimp. We got ourselves a convoy. Mr. Crull placed

the order himself.

MADELANE

My lord, we don't even have a freezer! You hold on. You call back later.

JIMMY

But, ma'am –

(Madelane hangs up, then calls Putt's hotel. Cajun music comes up.)

MADELANE

Hello, is this Hotel Le Grand? Hello? Will you please turn that music down? Is Mr. Putt Crull there? Tell him his sister is calling.

Putt, is that you? I can't hear you. How completely insensitive and inconsiderate. You know we don't have a freezer. They're gonna rot and stink up the whole neighborhood. They're gonna stink up the whole town! How many rum cokes have you had today? Putt, I can't hear you. Don't expect me to be here when you get back!

JIMMY

So I waited a little while, and I called again. Ma'am, is that you? Are you there? We gotta do something quick. We're parked on Front Street now. There's a Gulf station down at the end of the street. Ah, tres bien. I see a bunch of guys over there sitting on a bench. I'm gonna go and ask for directions. I'll see you in a few minutes. Au Revoir. Ma'am are you there?

(She slams down the receiver.)

MADELANE

Of all the stupid, inconsiderate ... I'm leaving. I'm going home to Michigan. Putt, I hope you choke on the stench!

(She takes off her apron and leaves it behind as she exits.)

JIMMY

Now Putt thought this was a pretty lowdown trick. For awhile. You know, as the vines covered the house and the dust built up in the parlor and the dishes stacked up in the sink. And then he and Madelane worked out their differences, and he hired a housekeeper, and pretty soon, he was back at the Hotel LeGrand kicking up his heels.

BARKSDALE

You see, Putt's problem is he should get married. A bachelor is a fellow who has failed to embrace his opportunities.

DASHED

ROY

Say, isn't that the Briscoe's Chevy across the street?

JOE

It sure is. You probably feel guilty remembering the bad job you did washing it.

ROY

Naw, I feel good. 'Cause it reminds me of a story. That was the car Charlyn and Renea were driving when young Bob and Billy got their put down. Remember that?

JOE

I sure do. Those two were sitting on a bench watching the grass grow when that sweet convertible came rolling by.

(Bob and Billy on the sidewalk, Charlyn and Renae in the car. Traveling music for the girls, maybe "Earth Angel.")

CHARLYN & RENEA

Hi, Bob! Hi, Billy!

BOB

Did you see that, Billy? They actually waved at us.

BILLY

Those girls are so pretty they shouldn't be allowed in the same car.

BOB

They waved at us. Us! Wow!

(The girls tour the stage, waving at the people, then return to Bob and Billy.)

CHARLYN & RENEA

Hi, Bob! Hi, Billy!

BILLY

Hi, Renea! Hi, Charlyn!

BOB

Hi! Hi, Renea!

(To Billy.)

Know what? If they come back again, I'm gonna see whether Renea will go with me and have a Co Cola.

BILLY

O sure, as if Renea would be seen with you. She'd sooner break out all over in poison oak.

(The girls come by again and stop.)

RENEA

Bob, would you come over here, please.

BOB

Man O Man.

BILLY

Go get 'em, tiger.

(On the way to the car, Bob bangs his knee on the corner of a platform.)

BOB

Hi, Renea.

RENEA

O, your poor knee. Bob, could you do something for me?

BOB

O sure, Renea. Anything you want.

RENEA

Bob, would you go inside the City Café and see whether Ronald Bond is in there? We'll circle back in a little while.

(Bob's hopes are dashed.)

BOB

OK, sure, Renea.

(He hobbles back to Billy.)

BILLY

Way to go, tiger.

JOE

Now, that's a good story. Bob will never forget it, and someday he'll see the funny side.

BARKSDALE

Let's say Renea had taken Bob up on that Co Cola, and he'd married her. It might turn out like an old codger I know. He said, "My wife is an angel who fell from heaven. Problem is, the parachute didn't open."

ROY'S BIRTHDAY CAKE

(Kate catches Dee and Jennie on the street.)

KATE

I'm running late and out of breath. But I just wanted to check on Roy's birthday cake. I want him to have a nice surprise on his birthday Especially since he got a job.

TEENAGE DEE

No problem. It will be there at five o'clock. Best birthday cake ever.

KATE

Thanks so much! I want a nice big cake to share with all Roy's friends. Say, how y'all doing with your new business enterprise?

TEENAGE JENNIE

Great. We're making some extra money for college

TEENAGE DEE

And we can spend our time telling talking about the good ol' Frog Pond. Like all the fun we use to have listening under the porches.

TEENAGE JENNIE

Which was how we got in trouble. That was a hoot!

UNDER THE PORCH: WINE MAKERS

(Grandpa and Grandma, along with Grandpa's sister, Lena. Little Dee and Little Jennie move in close to observe the action.)

GRANDPA

You children get on outa here. This is grownup talk. It ain't for you to hear.

(The children pause.)

GRANDMA

Hush, Howard. Anything you can say to me, you can say in front of these children. I won't allow anything indecent or disrespectful.

(The children go under the porch.)

GRANDPA

I'm only asking a little privacy. Maybe I'd like to talk about the old days when we weren't as perfect as we are now.

GRANDMA

Perfect! Poo!

GRANDPA

Like the time Lena and I made that wine. Ain't so, Lena?

LENA

Eh, what's that you say?

GRANDPA

Have I told that one before?

GRANDMA

Too many times. I want nothing to do with wine!

GRANDPA

That was a long time ago. Wasn't it Lena?

LENA

Speak up!

GRANDPA

That was over seventy years ago. In those days you had to stay overnight if you went from Alva to Winona. And Papa had jury duty in Winona. He would be gone for a few days or maybe longer. And he put Lena and me in charge of the store.

Not long after Papa left, we took in a big supply of raisins. Papa didn't come back and didn't come back, and we had to do something with those raisins. So we decided to make some ~~raisins~~.

LENA

You talking about wine, brother? That was my idea!

GRANDPA

Papa would be so mad if those raisins spoiled. And we did not want to make Papa mad. You did not want to make Papa mad.

LENA

It was my idea to make that wine.

GRANDPA

Maybe so. But I did all the work.

GRANDMA

Why would decent people brag about making wine!

GRANDPA

I got a churn and cleaned it up real good. I got a bucket of water and some sugar from the store. I cleaned the raisins. And I got a package of yeast and stirred it all up.

LENA

We waited and waited. Papa didn't come back. After a week, you brought me a small glass of wine to taste.

GRANDPA

You enjoyed tasting that wine.

LENA

For several nights you brought me a glass of wine to taste. I kept rolling it around in my mouth.

GRANDPA

And smacking your lips.

LENA

It was good. I mean real good!

Then Papa came home. He went to the store and walked up and down the aisles and asked, "What happened to those raisins?" I never could look Papa in the face and lie.

GRANDPA

No, you couldn't.

LENA

I said, "Howard made some wine." And – um – it was my idea.

GRANDPA

You did not not want to make Papa mad. We waited for him to get real mad. But he only said, "Bring me some." So I ran and got it, and Papa sipped it real slow.

LENA

Papa said, "This wine is good. This is real good."

GRANDPA

This wine didn't last long because Papa had to have a taste every night before supper.

LENA

And he always said, "This wine is good. This wine is real good."

CHILDREN

I want nothing to do with wine!

GRANDPA

Scat, you children. I'll be coming after you.

GRANDMA

Fine thing. Give wine to your father and tell the story in front of children. You're worse than Noah in the Bible. Next thing you know, they'll be telling it to their children.

UNDER THE PORCH: CHICKEN SNAKE

TEENAGE JENNIE

And then we'd run over to your house.

TEENAGE DEE

And get in trouble all over again.

(Mama, Daddy, and Aunt Ellen.)

MAMA

George, you hurry and get cleaned up. The preacher will be here any time.

DADDY

Yes, Ma'am! What we having?

MAMA

Fried chicken and gravy and five kinds of vegetables – squash and peas and snap beans and butter beans and new potatoes.

AUNTIE

And sweet potato pie.

DADDY

Mmm ... mmm. Preacher Wilkins will be so happy we'll whoosh right into heaven when we die. And if I die with sweet potato pie in my mouth, I'm gonna die happy.

MAMA

You hush and get to work. I got to finish up.

DADDY

Mmm ... mmm. Sweet potato pie!

(Mama exits. Enter Preacher Wilkins.)

PREACHER

Brother George. Sister Ellen.

DADDY

Why, Brother Wilkins. Welcome to our home.

AUNTIE

Welcome, Preacher.

PREACHER

How are you, brother? Sister?

DADDY

Middling, Preacher. But getting better. We're having sweet potato pie!

PREACHER

Mmm ... mmm.

(Little Dee and Little Jennie approach.)

LITTLE DEE

Did I hear sweet potato pie?

DADDY

Scoot, Dee, or you won't get any sweet potato pie. Preacher and I have serious matters to discuss.

AUNTIE

That don't concern you.

PREACHER

Bless you, children. Run along now.

(The children go under the porch.)

DADDY

Preacher, I've been troubled by a chicken snake.

PREACHER

You don't say.

DADDY

I don't like to bother you about it. But it's your department.

PREACHER

How's that?

DADDY

Well, this snake, like lots of other low-down critters, comes at night. A slippery kind of character, who comes in without a sound. He's partial to fresh eggs. Has a huge appetite for eggs. I'm afraid he's gonna eat me out of house and home.

PREACHER

Sounds bad, George. But how is that my department?

DADDY

Funny thing about this snake is, sometimes he takes a live chicken. He's been known to take a full-grown hen.

PREACHER

What would this snake be called?

DADDY

This snake would be called Henry – Henry Lee.

AUNTIE

That's right. Henry Lee.

PREACHER

Seems like a snake that also visits other folks' chicken coops.

DADDY

Yup. And here's where you come in, Reverend. Henry's gonna need help in shaking the devil.

PREACHER

You don't say.

DADDY

Last night Henry comes to visit the chicken coop. He opens the latch and slithers in, nice and quiet. And he goes tippy-toe to the hen roost. And he reaches into a nest, nice and quiet. And nice and quiet, he gets hold of a nice warm egg.

(Daddy shouts. Mama runs out of the house.)

Lord, Lord, help me! Come and get me! Come and get me!

MAMA

George, what in the world?

DADDY

It's OK, Mama. I was telling Preacher about the chicken snake.

MAMA

Henry Lee! For goodness sakes –

AUNTIE

Yes sir, Henry Lee.

DADDY

Henry is screaming and crying, "Come and get me. Come and get me." So I do. I grab the lantern and trot on down to the chicken coop and look inside. And there's Henry, and he's got a smashed egg in his fist, and there's a real live chicken snake wrapped round his arm, with its tongue licking egg and licking Henry too.

MAMA

Henry was so scared he could hardly walk.

DADDY

He was mumbling, "I seen Satan. I seen the serpent hisself."

MAMA

And he said, "The devil took me by the hand."

AUNTIE

The devil took him. Yes he did.

DADDY

I carried him home and set him down in a chair. And as far as I know, he's sitting there still. That's where you come in, Preacher. You gotta drive the devil out of Henry Lee.

PREACHER

No problem. Reckon it's take a two by four. But first let's get some fried chicken and sweet potato pie.

MAMA

Come on in. It's ready.

CHILDREN

Help, help, come and get me! Come and get me!

DADDY

I knew you were down there. You run along now.

AUNTIE

Or you won't get any sweet potato pie.

PREACHER

Mmm .. mmm. God's work cannot be done on an empty stomach.

KATE

Good stories. But I gotta run. Be sure you take that cake to Garner's station at five o'clock sharp.

TEENAGE DEE

We will.

TEENAGE JENNIE

You can count on it.

CONNECTED TO THE LAND

(Jean drives a small tractor on stage and stops.)

JEAN

At last a moment alone, peace and quiet and time to think. Might as well be an old mule as far as Stanley is concerned. Not that he ain't an old mule himself. Never known anything but work. It's not enough for him to sell insurance and real estate. No, he's got to have a hobby farm. And my jobs – canning, cleaning, bookkeeping, church work, public relations, not to mention mothering Stanley and the children.

I'm still a young woman, and it ain't right. He's twenty years older. His energizer bunny's running down a little. Now don't ask why I married him. All I can say is, he was younger once.

How did I get away for awhile? Here's how.

(Enter Stanley.)

We were out on the farm working in the fields. It was one those days. We'd been arguing. He kept thinking of reasons I shouldn't go. I'd say, "I've got to get some time to myself Stanley, or I'm gonna end up in Whitfield." Then he'd go off and work some more and come back with another reason.

STANLEY

It sure would be nice if you could take a few days off, but we're closing on the old Beauchamp place, who's gonna handle the paper work.

JEAN

And I'd try to explain to him I was in desperate shape, and he'd go off, and then he'd come running back.

STANLEY

It sure would be nice if you could get away, but think of all those muscadines we picked. That jelly has got to be put up.

JEAN

By the time he came back next time I had it figured out.

STANLEY

Jean, this is the week we planned to kill those chickens. And if we don't get it done ...

JEAN

Why yes, Stanley, you're absolutely right. I can't get away now. I can't wait to start cutting up those poor, unfortunate chickens.

STANLEY

Well, Jean, I'm glad you're finally getting some sense. You're a good girl.

(Jean jumps on the tractor and starts it up.)

JEAN

Whoeee! I flew out of there like a ~~free-range~~ chicken running for its life. *Terrified*

Just peace and quiet is all I wanted. But it's strange. I never got farther than the football field. Last time I was here it was full of screaming fans, and my Harold was down on the field, and Heather was out there with the cheerleaders. So long ago.

I remember when I was a little girl this was a cow pasture; over there was a little fishing pond. I remember how Mama loved to picnic here and pick blackberries and how she's fuss at Daddy for fishing on Sunday ...

(Enter Kate.)

KATE

Hi, Jean. Didn't see you there. Hope I'm not intruding.

JEAN

Nope, I'm just taking a break. From Stanley. Never wants to go anywhere. All he wants to do is work.

KATE

Wish I had that problem. All Roy wants to do is hang around with his friends. All no good loafers. But he finally got a job. Barksdale Garner has hired him.

JEAN

Wish I could get Stanley out of the house and off the farm. Maybe I'd have some peace.

That's why I came here. I was just thinking how this place used to be a pasture. And there was a pond where the concessions stand sits. I came here to remember this place the way it was.

KATE

I'm giving Roy a birthday party at Garner's today at five. In honor of his having a job. You come and drag Stanley along with you. Away from his fields. *AT LAST!*

JEAN

I'm sure gonna try. Where you headed? I'll give you a lift. *pleases*

KATE

OK, thanks. Take me to Avis's. I'm gonna get my hair done.

(They hop on the tractor and drive off. Women sing "Housewife Blues.")

GIRL TALK

(Avis's Beauty Parlor.)

KATE

Hope I'm not late.

AVIS

You're right on time.

KATE

I was just with Jennie and Dee, and those girls know how to talk, talk, talk, and tell stories. And then I ran into Jean. And first thing I had to do this morning is get Roy going. Barksdale's gonna fire him if he's not careful, and today's his birthday.

ORA

Getting fired might be a nice birthday present for him. A wake up call.

KATE

No way. I'm counting on Barksdale's good nature. And I want to do something nice for Roy. Buy him a birthday cake, get my hair fixed, and carry some food over to him and Barksdale and the other guys at the station. You're all invited.

ORA

Well, at least Roy's got a job. On the way over I saw Ned and Pearly and that poor Goat Cook sitting on the porch. They'll be passing the jug around and picking on him the way they always do. I can hear them now.

ALL

O yeah! White Lightning.

(The women sing "White Lightning." Others join.)

ORA

Know what, Goat? You should set your sights higher. Go into politics.

AVIS

You know the definition of politics, don't you Goat?

KATE

No I don't.

AVIS

Just look at the word. "Poli" means "many," and ticks are blood suckers. "Politics": "Many blood suckers."

KATE

You sure got that right. Taxes, car licenses, police bothering an honest man for taking a few drinks.

AVIS

There you go, Goat. You could set it to rights. No more taxes, no more speed limits, unlimited moonshine.

KATE

A man can hardly breathe in this town when you think of all the things you're not supposed to do. Like playing cards.

AVIS

Ol' Pearly here thinks card playing is a mighty big sin.

ORA

Watch it, Ned.

KATE

Aw, come on. Let's hear it. .

AVIS

Near as I can make out it happened last July. Hot, muggy day, big black clouds, thunder getting closer and closer. Then flash-boom, flash-boom. Then rain and deathly quiet. The light turns ghastly green.

Pearly's at home, playing a little poker with his missus, sister, and brother-in-law, taking a little pull from the jug. Pretty soon they hear it. Low and rumbling like a freight train, getting louder and louder, heading right at 'em. So Pearly gets scared and excited, and he jumps up and says, "Lord, Lord, if you'll only spare my life, I'll give up card playing and cussing and drinking too." Seems like Pearly is becoming a mighty good Christian. "I'll throw the cards in the fire, Lord."

Now they had a little fire for boiling tea, and Pearly puts the cards right in there, and they go out to the kitchen and lay down on the floor, and the funnel cloud passes overhead and does no damage at all. So Pearly, fine Christian man that he is, stands up and says, "Thank you, Lord, thank you so much."

They all go back in, a little wobbly in the knees, just to rest and breathe easy when Pearly spots the jug and has to take a sip to get his strength up, and he notices the cards at the back of the

fireplace, a little singed, but none the worse for wear. Pearly fishes them out and says, "Well, goldarnit, folks, the Lord has seen fit to save us. What do you say? Let's have another hand."

a strong Christian Faith
ORA

Well, when it comes to ~~belief~~, Ned's got us all beat. You heard about the funeral up in Duck Hill when ol' Pappy Rice jumped out of his coffin.

AVIS

Leave it alone, Pearly. Nobody's listening.

ORA

Yup, ol' Pappy Rice, fine upstanding man, a leading citizen of Duck Hill. Just one problem. They had to straighten him out and tie him down because rigor mortis had set in before they laid him in the coffin.

So the preacher is thumping and banging, saying when you pass them Heavenly Gates, the first shall be last and the last shall be first. It seems that Pappy, who happens to be headed for those Gates, gets all excited and sits up in his coffin.

It must be true that the last shall be first because the preacher who is farthest from the door is the first one through, even though he has to leave a footprint on Ned's back to get there. And that takes some effort, 'cause ol' Ned is a moving target. There are flowery hats rolling and ladies purses flying, and everybody thundering out behind the preacher and tumbling down the hill in a heap.

Ol' Pappy, sitting there in his coffin, has the church all to himself. They all thought he was a haunt 'cause some mischievous boys had cut the ropes and his rigor mortis made him pop up like a jack in the box.

AVIS

Forget about them haunts. Tell you what, Goat. You run for constable, and I'll be your campaign manager.

ORA

We got to have a campaign slogan.

AVIS

Here it is: Why vote for a good man and ruin him. Vote for Goat, he's already ruint.

(The real Goat enters.)

GOAT

They can laugh if they want to. But I'm really gonna do it. Throw the rascals out!

(He rushes off jug in hand.)

(They resume their real personalities.)

KATE

You know it's terrible how men are always telling stories against each other and putting each other down. I'm glad we're not like that.

ORA

What are we going to do with these men? Can't live with 'em, can't live without 'em.

AVIS

We could sure give it a try.

(The women sing another chorus of "Housewife Blues.")

POOR FLOYD I

(At Garner's Station.)

ROY

You know fellas it worries me sometimes that we're always playing tricks on each other and putting each other down. I'm trying to think of something nice. A story about doing good.

JIMMY

No problem. Just tell any story about Deputy Floyd Williams. He's an ~~authentic, certifiable,~~ genuine saint. Remember when Floyd stopped Miz Sumner for speeding. You know, it was her and her husband Pete who gave all that money for college scholarships.

JOE

I remember that she liked to drive fast.

(The sound of a siren)

FLOYD

Ma'am, could I see your license?

MIZ SUMNER

Here, you little whipper snapper!

FLOYD

Miz Sumner, you know you're not supposed to drive this fast. I'll have to give you a ticket.

MIZ SUMNER

Better give me two tickets.

FLOYD

Why's that?

MIZ SUMNER

'Cause I'm gonna drive this fast on the way home too!

JIMMY

Floyd did give her two tickets and behaved like a perfect gentleman the whole time.

BARKSDALE

I like stories about feisty women. Here's my favorite one.

There was a man and a woman riding on an airplane, sitting next to each other. The woman pulled out her Bible to read. The man asked her what she was reading. She said, "My Bible." He asked her if she believed everything in it. She said, "I do." He asked her if she believed the whale swallowed Jonah. She said, "I do."

"How do you know it ^{is} true?"

"Because Jonah said it was, and when I get to heaven, he will prove it."

"What if Jonah is not in heaven?"

"Then you ask him."

JIMMY

There's no doubt about Floyd's ~~destination~~. He had many crosses to bear, but the heaviest was Sheriff J. W. Herring. Folks called him God Dog It. 'Cause that's what he always said.

MEN

God dog it!

GOD DOG IT

JIMMY

Now God Dog It was a big man — prob'ly weighed 300 pounds — but he wasn't very brave. And when he was sheriff, he never liked to go on calls by himself. He'd usually take someone with him, and usually that someone was Floyd.

MEN

FLOYD

One night we went out on a report of domestic violence. It had been drizzling rain about two days, and the ground was wet and muddy. To get to the house, you had to follow a little driveway down a long slippery hill. There was no place to park down there, so we parked on the highway. Sheriff Herring says, "We're just gonna go down there and check things out. It probably ain't nothing to it. And when we get down there, they'll be smooching and making up and we can leave. But we need to walk down there and get under the house and listen to see if the man has a gun or knife or anything. Floyd, you go first."

MEN

God dog it!

FLOYD

We started down. I slipped and started to fall and grabbed onto a tree. Then Sheriff Herring fell. On his backside. He came sliding down that hill on his butt, picking up speed. He flew on past me faster than a greased pig; he slid all the way down to the bottom of the hill and slammed into an electric fence.

"O, O, God dog it help me, I'm dying. I'm dying. This thang's gonna kill me."

Now I tried to grab hold of his ankle to pull him off, and when I did, the electric fence got me. And I had to let him go. It was tearing me up, too. So I had to get down on my hands and knees in the mud and hit him with my shoulder.

MEN

God dog it!

FLOYD

Well, I finally got him loose. And when he caught his breath, Sheriff Herring says, "Now God dog it, Floyd, don't get caught up in that thang 'cause it'll kill you. Don't do it now, boy. Don't do it."

Meanwhile, those folks had made up, and that little cabin was rocking with love. Lucky we didn't have to go to the door. I was soppin' wet, filthy as a hog, and 'lectrocuted for no reason at all. When we got back to the car, Sheriff Herring says, "God dog it, boy, I didn't think them 'lectric fences was too bad, but they will tear up your ass, especially when it's raining."

MEN

God dog it!

CEMETERY LIGHTS

(Kate and the Memory Mama with her children. Kate sits down on a bench next to the Memory Mama.)

KATE

I hope you won't mind if I join you. I'm out of breath from too much running around.

MEMORY MAMA

Tell me all about it, honey. I'm pooped.

KATE

I apologize for my bad memory, but I don't think I know you.

MEMORY MAMA

But I know you and everybody else as well. And everybody's business. I'm called the Memory Mama, and these are my children.

FIRST CHILD

We help her keep track of the whole county's memories and the memories of all the neighboring counties.

SECOND CHILD

And we keep track of her when she gets mixed up keeping track of so many memories.

MEMORY MAMA

Kate, I'm worried about you and your friends. You're doing a nice thing in giving Roy a birthday party ...

KATE

How did you know?

MEMORY MAMA

I always know. As I was saying, I'm worried about the stories you and your friends are telling. They're amusing, but they don't touch the heart. Folks around here have done great things. And they have suffered great tragedies.

KATE

I know they have. But right now I have to get going. I have errands to do.

MEMORY MAMA

Too much hurry wears away the soul. You have to take time to listen. Now listen to the voices.

Do you know the story of the cemetery lights? Do you about the woman who built a touching memorial of light for her dead daughter? She once told the story to a young woman from the North who was visiting the cemetery.

CEMETERY LIGHTS

(Mary and Mother)

MARY

Do you mind if I ask why you've decorated that tombstone with Christmas lights?

MOTHER

I know it's out of season. But I felt I had to get out here and put something pretty on her grave.

MARY

But Christmas lights?

MOTHER

I come out here at least once a week and bring flowers and chat with her, and sometimes there's a pair of mockingbirds just singing their hearts out, and I like to think it's Emmy and her friends enjoying the nice weather. You know, Evelyn Smiley is buried here, who died in the car crash, and those children who died in the fire. I like to think they play with each other. But sometimes it's so dark and gloomy.

MARY

So you decorate with Christmas lights. Don't think I'm judging you.

MOTHER

You couldn't judge me harder than I judge myself. If I'd only let her go out with that boy.

MARY

You don't have to talk about it.

MOTHER

I do have to talk. I do. You see, we had this awful fight. We often fought, but this one was the worst. We yelled at each other and said terrible things. I insulted her and her boyfriend, and she ran upstairs crying. It seems so stupid now. How could I have known?

Later, she snuck down to the kitchen and swallowed rat poison. I heard her screaming and came rushing downstairs and saw what she'd done, and I knew it would take forever to get an ambulance. So we dragged her to the car and took off for the hospital. My son was driving. She was crying in the back seat. We had the window down and were yelling for help and blowing the

horn and driving as fast as we could. And we hit something – a big rock, I think – and blew a tire. But we didn't stop, and the wheel was thumping and grinding and smoking and fire was flying. It was so far to Winona. It took so long to get there.

She lingered two days. And she died. I can't stand it, but I've got to talk.

MARY

I know. I know.

MOTHER

There's nothing I can do to make amends. So I just come out here to be with her and do all the nice things I can. I have to hope she'll get over it somehow, wherever she is, get over it and forgive me, because I sure can't forgive myself. She was sixteen.

MARY

There, there ... My daughter Jennifer was only ten months when she died. She was fine when I took her to day care. One afternoon they put her down for her nap, and she never woke up. They called it SIDS: Sudden Infant Death Syndrome. I blamed everybody – the day care, the doctor. Most of all I blamed myself. I should have given up my career to take care of her. That's what I told myself. And my husband blamed me, silently. We don't talk about it.

MOTHER

I'm sorry. You have your own problems. I'm a terrible person, I know

MARY

You're not a terrible person. Your Christmas lights are beautiful. They bring light to the children and remind me of an old story about the souls of the dead standing like angels on the lids of their coffins. They remind me that life goes on. The dead do live. I truly believe that.

(Exit Mary and Mother.)

SPOOKY CANYON

MEMORY MAMA

There's a story we should never forget.

KATE

It breaks your heart. I sympathize even though I don't have children myself. 'Course I've got Roy.

MEMORY MAMA

You don't have to be a mother to feel what a mother feels and know what a mother knows. You

remember hearing about Paragoric Annie, who lived in a piano box/out in Spooky Canyon. She never had any children, but she sure knew how to feel like a mother.

(Annie and Rose.)

ANNIE

What's wrong? Can't you tell ol' Paragoric Annie. Well, if you won't talk, Annie can't help you. I know something is wrong. If it wasn't, you wouldn't be out here in Spooky Canyon. 'Cause little girls don't come out here. Only boys to have fun and to do mischief.

Except for me. I live right over there behind that rock. In a piano box. That's because there's something wrong with me. They say I'm crazy. And I agree with 'em. I'm nuttier'n a fruitcake. 'Cause I'm too fond of the ol' paragoric.

What's your name, child?

ROSE

Rose.

ANNIE

So what's wrong with you?

ROSE

My uncle.

ANNIE

Hmm ...

ROSE

He pulls my hair and bats me aside the head.

ANNIE

And?

ROSE

He treats me bad. Just like mean people treat their dogs. I have to cook his cornbread and bring him his supper and do everything he asks because my Mama says we need the money and have to work for him. Or he pulls my hair and bats me aside the head. And he treats my mama bad. He throwed us out of our house 'cause he said he owns it. And now we live in a shack.

ANNIE

I know you don't want to be treated like no dog. There's such a thing as human dignity. We have rights.

ROSE

Yes, Ma'am. I got back at him. I burn't his cornbread, and when he asked me for a cold drink of water, I let it sit out in the sun. And I stuck my finger in it.

ANNIE

That's my girl. Just like when they treated me mean and called me crazy, I didn't set around Winona like an old dog waiting to be kicked. I came out here to live by myself. All of this is mine. All of this trash and refuse and roots and rocks and rats. It's Annie's Spooky Canyon. Paragoric Annie's World of Wrong.

Now what are you doing out here?

ROSE

I ran away from home.

ANNIE

With an uncle like that, I don't blame you.

Listen, Rose. You must go straight home to your mama. And tell her everything you told me. Then both of you go to Sheriff Herring, and tell him everything too. Sheriff Herring is OK. I know him pretty well. I should. I've spent a heap of time in his jail. Go on now.

ROSE

Yes, Ma'am.

(Rose and Annie exit.)

MEETCOMING

MEMORY MAMA

You see what I mean, Kate, there are some serious stories about suffering and nobility right here at home. And there has been greatness too. And you know, what strikes me is how lightly folks carry it off. They never forget where they came from. Take, for example, the blues singer John Hurt, who was from Avalon, just next door in Carroll County. Part of his story has been told by his granddaughter, Mary Frances Hurt Wright. Mary Frances was teaching in Chicago, and one day she stopped in to have lunch with a friend from Mississippi.

MARY FRANCES

Dee, I hope I'm not bothering you, but I need to talk with someone from Mississippi.

DEE

Talk away.

MARY FRANCES

Well, I just came back from Mississippi, and I want to tell you about a wonderful experience.

DEE

Great. I could use a lift. This has been a very tough morning.

MARY FRANCES

I often dream about the South and think about it, and sometimes I go there to visit my grandfather's old house. You might have heard of him. The song writer and blues singer, John Hurt. They call him Mississippi John Hurt.

DEE

Of course. He was from Avalon.

MARY FRANCES

He was a good man and a brave man. In his sixties he left home to pursue a recording and concert career in Memphis and New York and all over the country. He played for huge audiences. I know it scared him. He had hardly ever traveled in his whole life. And do you know why he did it? To make enough money to send his grandchildren to college.

(Enter Dave Murphy.)

I was at my grandfather's house taking pictures and wondering what this run-down house filled with had to do with my life, when a man came up behind me. His name was Dave Murphy.

DAVE

Have you come about the house?

MARY FRANCES

I have. How did you know?

DAVE

God told me someone would come about the house. I have been saving it for a member of John's family.

MARY FRANCES

This is Daddy John's house. I'm Mary Frances, his granddaughter.

DAVE

Then the house is yours for five thousand dollars.

(To Dee and the audience.)

MARY FRANCES

I didn't know where I would get five thousand dollars. But I went to see Mr. Pate Shackleford at the local bank. My grandfather Richardson had done business at that bank, and when Mr. Pate learned who I was and that I wanted to buy the John Hurt house, he said he would give me a check the following day.

(To Dave.)

Mr. Murphy, I have the money for the house.

DAVE

Sorry, Ma'am, I can't sell you the house. Folks here are always complaining about the tourist traffic. And the house is such a mess, it cannot stay here. I can't sell it to you, but I'll give it to you. If you move it.

(Dave exits.)

MARY FRANCES

So I looked up a house mover, and he said it would cost exactly five thousand dollars to move. And, Dee, does it surprise you that I knew exactly where to move it and what to do with it?

DEE

In this story, nothing surprises me!

MARY FRANCES

I know that God was guiding me, and that he guided Mr. Murphy and Mr. Shackleford. I knew the house would become the John Hurt Museum, and I knew I would move it onto my mother's family's land. Richardson land. I didn't have one thing to put inside the museum, but I was determined to go ahead.

DEE

That doesn't surprise me.

(Enter Art Browning playing John Hurt music.)

MARY FRANCES

I started cleaning furiously. I mean furiously. I was taking out my feelings on the dust and the dirt. Mice and crickets and cockroaches were running for their lives.

ART

Whatcha doing?

MARY FRANCES

What does it look like I'm doing?

ART

Sorry to bother you. I was looking for the John Hurt house, and I see I found it. I was confused on account of its being moved.

MARY FRANCES

What do you want with the John Hurt house?

ART

I just want to take a picture. What are you going to do with it?

MARY FRANCES

I'm John Hurt's granddaughter, and with God's help, I'm gonna turn this house into a museum.

ART

Pleased to meetch'ya. I'm Art Browning, and I'm just the man you're looking for. I'm going home to get my stuff.

(Art exits playing and singing.)

MARY FRANCES

When Art came back, I apologized for being rude. Before long, I realized I had been talking to my good angel. It turned out Art had been collecting John Hurt memorabilia for over twenty years. His house was full of magazines and books and pictures and records and sheet music and brochures and programs, and he gave it all to the John Hurt Museum. And he volunteered to be the caretaker.

The museum is still there; Art is still there; and we've had two John Hurt festivals. Does that surprise you?

DEE

Not at all!

MARY FRANCES

I just thought somebody from Mississippi needed to hear this story and to learn how God guides us every step of the way. Oops, I'm late for class. See y'all later. We should do this more often.

DEE

Yes, we should. *I'm feeling much better*

(Mary Frances and Dee exit. Art Browning enters and plays Lost Jim's "Daddy John" to end the act. The cast participates.)

INTERMISSION

ACT II

ON A MISSION

ROY

Hi. I'm back. And I'm not skipping out of work either. I'm on special assignment. You see, just a little while ago I says to Barksdale, I've been working hard and doing good, and I wonder if you'd give me a promotion. And he says, "Roy, that's a little premature," or "presumptuous" or something like that. "But I'll send you on an errand. I want you to go up to the courthouse and into the streets and pick up some stories and bring 'em back here. He says, "Remember, no matter what your past, your future is spotless."

Folks, I'm on ~~my~~ way to ~~the~~ future!

(Kate appears.)

KATE

Roy!

ROY

O no!

KATE

Why aren't you at work?

ROY

I am at work. I'm on a mission.

KATE

You'd better be. I'm gonna stop by the station at five o'clock to check up on you.

ROY

Aw, come on, Kate.

KATE

You be there!

ROY

All right, I will. Yackity yack

(Kate exits. Judge Boatman and Malcolm have overheard.)

JUDGE

Roy, you remind me of the dentist who married the manicurist. They've been at it tooth and nail ever since. I heard that one from Barksdale. 'Course I told it to him first. He liked it so well he told it back to me.

MALCOLM

Tell him about Jesse James, Judge.

JUDGE

Nothing to tell. He's still on the moon eating green cheese. But come with me, Roy. There's a fella over here telling lies. He says ol' Jesse ain't on the moon. Can you imagine the gall. Can you, Malcolm?

MALCOLM

No sir! My mama says Grandpa tells tall tales.

(Grandpa and children. The Jesse James song.)

JESSE JAMES RIDES AGAIN

FIRST CHILD

Grandpa, tell us some Jesse James stories.

GRANDPA

Well, what do you want to hear?

SECOND CHILD

Tell us how you rode with Jesse James' outlaw gang.

GRANDPA

Jesse and I were great friends. Jesse and I and Billy the Kid. We had our hideout the other side of Lodi. We'd go there and get rested up. We got so tired riding after all those trains we robbed we just flopped down on the ground.

We laid there dozing by the fire, our ears pressed to the ground. When a train was coming, you could feel the ground shaking ever so little, and you heard ever so faintly, the clickety-clack of the wheels. Clickety-clack, clickety-clack, clickety-clack ...

(Grandpa establishes a rhythm; the children follow.)

And when the train was still far off, the wheels seemed to be saying “a-Poplar Creek, a-Poplar Creek, a-Poplar Creek ...” Always getting a little bit louder.

Our eyes were wide open. But we kept our ears to the ground. And sometimes the train would cross a trestle. And then for a little while, the wheels would say “Lodi, Lodi, Lodi ...”

For just a little while. And then it was “a-Poplar Creek, a-Poplar Creek, a-Poplar Creek ...” And pretty soon we heard it blow for a crossing. “Aooooah! Aooooah! Aooooah!” We jumped to our feet. We vaulted into the saddle, and we were off. Hi ho, Silver, away!

FIRST CHILD

Then what happened, Grandpa?

GRANDPA

What happened is too scary to talk about. All the yelling and the hooting and the shooting. And the smoke and the steam and the whistle blowing and the screeching brakes.

‘Course there was no cursing or swearing or anything like that. Jesse wouldn’t allow it.

SECOND CHILD

Did you get the gold, Grandpa?

GRANDPA

O sure, bags and bags of gold.

FIRST CHILD

Where’s the gold now?

GRANDPA

We buried it under a big pile of rocks. Not far from here, but in a secret place. We had to vamoose and couldn’t carry all that gold. We headed west. We followed the railroad tracks so we could rob more trains. Long, long tracks stretching towards the west, shining in the sun. The sound of the wind and the train whistles were singing in our ears. We went all the way to places like El Paso and Alamagordo and Tucson.

SECOND CHILD

Tell about the holes in the barn door, Grandpa.

GRANDPA

You tell it. You’ve heard that story many times.

SECOND CHILD

Well, a posse had Jesse and Grandpa and Billy the Kid and the outlaw gang trapped in the barn. And they shot holes in the door. They didn't know that Grandad and the others had already lit out for the high Sierras.

GRANDPA

All correct. Great job!

JUDGE

Lies, lies! Falsehoods and prevarications! Jesse James is on the moon eating green cheese.

(Enter Goat.)

GOAT

Where's the judge? I got to find the judge.

JUDGE

I'm the judge 'round here. Judge of Choctaw, Montgomery, and Carroll counties, all the way from Stewart to Vaiden, and everywhere in between.

GOAT

That's good. I got to know what I have to do to run for political office.

JUDGE

Why, Goat, that's simple. All you have to do is be a resident and be registered to vote. Everybody knows that.

GOAT

Register to vote? What's that?

JUDGE

You got to go to the courthouse and get signed up to vote.

GOAT

I ain't never voted in my life!

(Chasing Goat off stage.)

JUDGE

Get outa here, Goat. You are a disgrace to this great Republic.

Come on, Malcolm. Let's go fishing. We'll go through the town where all them pretty girls are driving round and round and round ...

(They exit singing. Roy is left alone.)

ROY

You know that ol' Judge is right. Being near the courthouse reminds me this is a great Republic. Sometimes it's good just to sit down and think. Here's the old soldier always on guard. He reminds me of the men who went out from here to serve their country. Some of 'em not very long ago. I remember young Lynn Crowder, who served in Vietnam. There's a story going round about Pete Small, and how Pete came back to town and how he was wandering around the courthouse late at night and how he met Lynn Crowder right here by the old soldier.

SOLDIERS

(Pete Small and Lynn Crowder. Crowder is in uniform.)

LYNN

Hi. Nice night for a walk.

PETE

Nice and cool. You with the National Guard?

LYNN

Nope, just looking around.

PETE

In town for a visit?

LYNN

You could say that. I come back every once in a while. You know, just trying to figure things out.

PETE

Like what, for example?

LYNN

Well, I keep going over it in my mind. We were at a place called Cam Le Bridge.

PETE

You mean outside Da Nang?

LYNN

Yeah, that's the place. You been to Cam Le Bridge?

PETE

It had a reputation.

LYNN

Well, Delta Company was assigned to guard the bridge leading to the Da Nang airbase, and Mr. Charlie wanted that base. So that night he let us have it. Small arms, mortars, RPG's.

All hell broke loose. Some of my buddies went down. I got blown off a bunker. Then I started tossing grenades. Cussing and screaming and hellish noise went on most of the night and all morning. At some point an RPG got me, and while ol' Kid was carrying me back, I noticed my arm was mostly gone. That's about it.

PETE

So you died at Cam Le Bridge.

LYNN

Reckon I must have. And I come back here sometimes. Because it's so quiet, especially at night. There's the old soldier. He sure is quiet, and there's the cross on the Methodist Church and the dome of the Presbyterian Church.

A little while ago I went walking on Front Street, past the old picture shows and over to City Café, where I used to pine after Sharon Hales. Way out of my league. You been to Vietnam?

PETE

First Cavalry.

LYNN

I got there December sixty seven. The battle of the Bridge happened August twenty-third.

PETE

A couple of months into my tour I got the million dollar wound. Caught a load of shrapnel in my rear end.

LYNN

So why were you showing your butt to the enemy?

PETE

Round landed behind me. Took Mailman's head off. I'd just relieved him on point. I was out in front, and he was the guy who died.

I went a little nuts after I got back – too much dope and booze. Mailman had written a little poem. I made everybody listen to it. If they wouldn't I'd beat the crap out of 'em:

“In Vietnam that horror, that horrible place, the real hell. The young bloods’ green turned to red, for there is no friend in Vietnam, not people, snake, or rat. Not grass, heat, sun or rain, not day, not night, not even friendly fire. ...” About then, if they weren’t paying attention, I’d smack ‘em. I’d still be like that if I hadn’t met my wife.

So you’re Lynn Crowder. Lance Corporal Crowder.

LYNN

Hey, that’s right. How did you know?

PETE

I read about you. And now I recognize you. Pete Small.

LYNN

Pete Small. Didn’t they call you Pete the Geek?

PETE

I don’t think the girls would like me any better now than they did then. They pick the likes of us to fight our nation’s wars.

LYNN

Pete, You sound like a damyankee.

PETE

The family moved north many years ago. To Winona, Minnesota, of all places.

LYNN

My best friend was from the North. A black man from Balitmore. John Thomas. Only I called him Kid ‘cause he was just eighteen. My handle was Critter. We hardly ever used our right names.

PETE

I was Gopher.

LYNN

No point in getting too friendly. But ‘ol Kid and I hit it off. Best buddy I ever had. Saved my life a couple of times. Had that sixth sense. Knew what was going to happen before it happened. At the Bridge maybe I returned the favor. I sure hope so. I wonder if he made it.

PETE

I could check the wall for you.

LYNN

That's OK. Doubt if we'll see each other again. While I'm here, I think I'll go over to my folks' house and stand out in front for awhile. Maybe have a look at my old room. They keep it just the same as when I graduated high school in sixty-five. I don't scare them anymore. They kind of like knowing I'm around. I was their only son.

PETE

Lynn, I want to thank you.

LYNN

Why, 'cause I got wasted for my country? Made the supreme sacrifice?

PETE

No, for talking with me. You helped me understand. I appreciate it.

LYNN

No problem Take care, Pete. Gopher.

PETE

So long, Critter.

(Lynn and Pete exit. Roy remains alone.)

SHORTS

ROY

Sometimes, when I come downtown, it seems the stories are just swimming through the air like fish in a pond. It seems all I'd have to do is put out my hand and grab 'em. But where are they?

(Enter Mayor Fred Watts.)

FRED

They're right here, Roy.

ROY

Mr. Mayor, Mr. Fred, I didn't see you standing there.

FRED

All you have to do is be quiet and listen. Just listen to the voices. Our voices.

PEANUT AND THE CLOTHES DRYER

(Father and son.) music from 52's

SON
Dad, Dad, turn ~~on~~ the radio quick. It's Peanut.

FATHER
Peanut Holmes? I hope you're not hanging around with him again.

SON
No, no, he's gonna be on the radio. WLS Chicago.

DAD
Peanut Holmes on WLS? I didn't know he moved to Chicago.

SON
No, no we were at the Bugs Bunny Laundromat. Listen.

DAD
I was hoping Peanut had moved.

ANNOUNCER
And way down in Winona, Mississippi, comes word of a new world's record. A young man by the name of Peanut Holmes has ridden a clothes dryer for one thousand revolutions. Congratulations, Peanut, on this very worthwhile endeavor, an example of good 'ol American ingenuity. And now let's hear it from Elvis. ...

SON
See, Dad, Peanut got inside the dryer and I held the door open a little to keep Peanut from smothering, and I kept poking in dimes. And Peanut hung in there for one thousand revolutions. Pretty great, huh?

FATHER
You stay away from Peanut Holmes. He ain't worth a ~~top~~. *Yankee doodle -*

SON
What do you mean, Dad? Peanut'll go far.

FATHER
Peanut ain't going nowhere but round and round and round

(Father and son exit.)

TROPHY

(Two women enter; one carries a trophy behind her back.)

FRED

What's wrong here?

FIRST WOMAN

When our daddy died he left us a trophy he'd won in a lodge raffle. He thought it was beautiful and kept it on the mantle. It's a fake Grecian urn made of molded plastic and painted gold with rubber grapes glued to the top.

FRED

Where's the trophy now?

FIRST WOMAN

Minnie has it.

SECOND WOMAN

That's correct. Here it is.

FRED

Whew! That's ugly. What's the problem.

SECOND WOMAN

We're fighting over it. I want her to take it, and she wants me to keep it.

FIRST WOMAN

We're each trying to get rid of it.

FRED

Why not just throw it away.

SECOND WOMAN

We can't.

TOGETHER

It belonged to our daddy!

FRED

Intelligent people should be able to figure this out. College educated, are you?

FIRST WOMAN

I'm a proud graduate of Ole Miss.

SECOND WOMAN

State is my school.

FRED

Are you sports fans?

TOGETHER

Big time!

FRED

All right, here's what you do. Next week, Minnie, you take the trophy to the football game. If Ole Miss wins, you have to keep it. But if State wins, you give it to Winnie. The trophy is what you get for being a loser.

TOGETHER

What a wonderful idea! Thank you so much!

(They exit. Ronald Johnson enters.)

SELF DEFENSE

JOHNSON

Excuse me, Mr. Mayor, I just shot a man. Don't think it hurt him much. But I need to talk to somebody.

FRED

Do you have a lawyer?

JOHNSON

Don't think I need one. Don't think I'm guilty.

FRED

What happened?

JOHNSON

Well, Turl Bates came creeping around my house while I was at work. I'm driving the bob truck with a load of cattle, and I happen to drive past my house and see his car. So I go inside and peak in the bedroom, and I see Turl with my wife. I get my shotgun down from over the fireplace and cuss out Turl, and he yells at me, and well, sir, I shot him.

FRED

Did you shoot in self defense.

JOHNSON

No, sir. I shot him in de ass as he jumped over de fence.

FRED

Nice shot. Probably did ol' Turl some good. Keep him from sitting around the house too much. You better get home and make up with your wife.

(Johnson exits.)

There, Roy. See how it goes.

ROY

Thanks, Mr. Mayor. I am truly blessed. When I carry these stories to the station, I'll be like a water boy bringing back the necessity of life. I'm sure to get promoted.

NORA'S STORY

(Kate and Ora.)

KATE

Hi, Ora. I just stopped by to make sure you're going to deliver those flowers to Roy down at Barksdale's. Then I'm headed over to Maxine's to pick up the food.

ORA

O sure, no problem. But sit yourself down. Have I got a story to tell. You're gonna be surprised. Nora's back.

KATE

You don't mean it. I thought she moved to Indiana.

ORA

She did move up North to be with her sister after her husband Charley died. But then her sister died, and now she's back. I found her sitting on a bench with a can of bug spray.

(Nora and Ora.)

Nora is that you?

NORA

If these skeeters would just leave me alone, everything would be all right. And if Charley would do something more than drive that old mule up and down the street and give me some money to buy clothes for the children and put food on the table ... My sister's dead.

ORA

Can you hear me, Nora?

NORA

‘Course. I ain’t deaf. I work as hard as I can in other folks’ houses taking care of their children and never did earn enough to live on, and there never seems to be enough money, and these skeeters, I swear, are trying to chew me up entirely.

My sister died up in East Chicago. That’s how I come back to Winona and how come I ain’t got a home. I just don’t know how I can keep my children in school and keep shoes on their feet unless Charlie stops drinking and we get more money ...

ORA

Nora, I’ll get some help.

NORA

I’d be just fine ‘cept for these skeeters.

ORA

Who should I get in touch with?

NORA

It’s these blessed skeeters.

(Mimi enters.)

MIMI

O, Nora, there you are. I heard you came back home, but I couldn’t find you. O, No-No, it’s Mimi ...

(To Ora.)

I knew Nora was in town, but I’ve been so busy and distracted, I couldn’t find time to go see her. When I was a little girl, No-No took care of us in spite of all her troubles.

(To Nora.)

You loved us, No-No, and played with us and taught us quilting and putting up preserves and how to sew on our own buttons ...

NORA

(To Ora.)

Seems like I never had time for my own children, and now they don’t visit me and probably don’t

even know where I am. And none of those white children visit either, and I can't hardly remember them. And my children are my own flesh and blood. Now, my sister, she took me in. My sister's in East Chicago.

MIMI

The main way she helped us she didn't even know. I was after Mama died and Charlie died and Nora had gone to live with her sister, and I was a young teacher living in upstate New York.

There were hills like these, but it was cold. The hills were cold, and the people were cold too. I was so homesick and what kept me alive was knowing I had family down here who loved me. Nora wasn't my flesh and blood family. Her life was full of troubles. She was torn in all directions, just like me.

(To Nora.)

Most of all No-No I remember how you loved me, even when I was bad, and how you always told me I could be anything I wanted to be, no matter what.

(Mimi sings.)

There will come a time when your wings grow tired and you'll want to take to a tree;
You can't give in till the sun goes down; you can come and fly with me.

(Mimi and Nora sing together.)

Fly away,
Baby, you can fly away.
Fly away to the sun.
Fly away, Baby, you can fly away.
Your life has just begun.
Your life has just begun.

(To:)

MIMI

You're going to have a nice home, No-No. You won't have to worry about those skeeters any more.

NORA

Is that you, little Mimi? It's nice to see my children again. So I can take good care of 'em.

(Nora rejoins Kate.)

ORA

I know that Charley made life difficult for Nora, but he was a beloved figure going around town

with his old mule, plowing folks' gardens. The children loved him and followed him everywhere. He was a great storyteller.

A MAN AND HIS MULE

(Charley carries a harness. His appearance is accompanied by John Hurt's "Payday.")

CHARLEY

Sometimes I can't rightly remember whether I'm supposed to be dead or alive. I'm old as Methusaleh, that's sure. I ate the core of the apple when Adam and Eve threw it out the garden. Could be dead I suppose. But you know I'm a survivor. I've lived through all kinds of scrapes. Ever hear about the time me and Payday got hit by a truck?

Yes sir, we was crossing 82 Highway like we always do. Then bang, out of nowhere. Never heard it, never saw it coming. Bang. Next thing I know I'm laying in the road looking at a bunch of black and white angels. But ol' Payday is standing there too, with a mighty worried look on his face. So it couldn't have been heaven. 'Cause Payday ain't got no soul. And there was Dr. Howard, and he looks worried too. And he says, "Charley Harvey, you get right up outa that road. You're liable to get run over." So I did. Didn't want to disappoint him, and I was feeling real sorry for Payday, he looked so worried. Take more'n a truck to kill me, I reckon.

Well, I got some gardens to plow. I gotta find ol' Payday and get him hitched up. Get back to work.

(Exits to John Hurt's "Payday.")

KATE

Ora, I gotta ask a favor. I hate to ask it after such wonderful stories. But I have mischief in mind.

ORA

Go ahead.

KATE

When you take the flowers to Barksdale's station, I want you to play a little joke. Go a few minutes before five and let the cat out of the bag. Tell 'em there's going to be a party, and tell 'em there will be food. And describe the food. Not the food they're really gonna get, but all them delicacies and casseroles and finger foods that they hate. You know, everything with fruits and vegetables and no meat. Make 'em suffer.

ORA

Sounds like fun!

KATE

Then when we actually bring the food, it will be all that greasy ~~disgusting~~ stuff they love – fried chicken and gravy and deer meat. Now I got to rush over to Maxine's to help her carry it to Garner's. She's been slaving over a hot stove all afternoon.

POOR FLOYD II

(Kate and Maxine, both in nurse's uniforms.)

KATE

Mmm ... Something sure smells good.

MAXINE

Just about finished.

KATE

I don't see how you did it, girl. Considering the shift we had last night.

MAXINE

I know what you mean. Poor Floyd. I thought he was a goner. I thought we were goners.

KATE

Poor Floyd!

(Kate and Maxine at the hospital. Floyd enters.)

FLOYD

O my back! I can't stand up! Somebody get me a chair! It was God Dog It done this. First, he almost gets me killed in a 'lectric fence accident. And now he's broke my back.

KATE

Poor baby!

MAXINE

Tell us what happened.

FLOYD

We were in court, and Mr. Herring stood up to testify in the witness box. Maybe he stood up too fast. I dunno. Maybe he ate too much pork. He reached out to me. "Help me, Floyd, help me, boy. I'm going down."

I shoved a chair under him. His eyes closed. His face got white as his shirt. I said, "Mr. Herring, I'll call the ambulance or Dr. Middleton." And he woke up: "No ambulance, God Dog It, and no Dr. Middleton. Just take me home to Etolia." I said, "How can I do that? I can't carry you, and you can't walk." And he said, "This here chair's got wheels, don't it? God dog it, wheel me home to Etolia."

But God Dog It was so heavy, he was mashing down so hard on them wheels, it got harder and harder to push him. And then the wheels broke.

By that time we were close to my car. God Dog It pulled a little with his arms, and I was pushing and pulling and straining and staggering ...

THE WOMEN

Poor Floyd!

FLOYD

And finally I kinda rolled and butted him into the seat. We drove until we came back to his house and stopped outside, and Mr. Herring said, "God dog it, Floyd, I can make it from here. Thanks for your help. Etolia, Etolia, I'm coming home."

(Floyd stands up and immediately collapses.)

I got under him, but I couldn't hold him. And he said, "O God dog it. God dog it, boy, I'm going down." And I said, "You're going down; I'm going down; we're both going down, 'cause I can't hold you up. And God Dog It was calling, "Etolia, Etolia, Etolia." It was pathetic. And my back was killing me.

THE WOMEN

Poor Floyd!

FLOYD

I crawled up the front steps, and Etolia got a hold of his arms and pulled him, and somehow we belly-flopped him through the door, and he was home. Etolia was patting his sweaty head, and God Dog It was full of gratitude. "Thank you, Floyd. Thank you, boy."

My back is ruined! I tell ya ruined! O my back!

Wait a minute. Hold on now. My back feels better. I'm OK. I'm cured. Thanks, Maxine. Thanks, Kate. You stretched me out like an old wire fence. I'm cured!

MAXINE

O, O, my back! I can't stand up! I'm ruined forever.

(Returning to present time.)

Fortunately, we were so busy last night I had to get over that in a hurry. I'm OK now.

KATE

Let me help you finish up. And then we'll head for Barksdale's and Roy's big bash. They're gonna love your food.

BARKSDALE AND THE CHILDREN

(At Garner's station. Barksdale, Roy, and Jimmy. Some children enter: Ruth, Cindy, Bob, and Henry.)

RUTH

Mr. Barksdale, could you give us a candy bar?

CINDY

Please?

BARKSDALE

On one condition. Promise me, you'll look both ways before you cross the street. And when you're over by the picture show, waiting for the bus, stand way back from the curb. I won't tolerate my friends getting run over.

ALL

We will, Mr. Barksdale!

BARKSDALE

All right, here's a Baby Ruth for Ruth. And one for Cindy. And here's an O'Henry for Henry. And one for Bob.

BOB

Thank you, sir. Do you think Mr. Paul would give us a free Pepsi?

BARKSDALE

It wouldn't hurt to ask. But here's the test. You cross the street and the railroad tracks to see whether Mr. Paul will give you a free Pepsi. And you look both ways and up and down the tracks. I'm gonna be watching you, and if you don't look, I'm going over there and drink that Pepsi myself.

ALL

Yes sir!

(The children exit carefully – being sure to look in all directions. Three older children – Drit, Chuck, and Emily – enter.)

JIMMY

You kids get out of the street before you get killed!

CHUCK

No sir, we got a right to be here.

EMILY

We got our own vehicle.

DRIT

The world famous Dritmobile. I'm gonna take her for a run down cemetery hill. But first we gotta fill up.

BARKSDALE

That won't even take a whiff from the hose. Where's your gas tank, young Mr. Drit?

DRIT

No, you gotta fill us up. We're gonna buy some soda pop to carry us up that hill. We're going clear to the top – way up by the Billingsleys and Aldridges.

BARKSDALE

Here's the deal. You can take the pop on credit. If you're still in one piece after the test run, you can pay for it then.

ALL

All right! Thank you, sir!

CHUCK

Let me drive, Drit.

EMILY

Me first!

DRIT

Nope, I built it. I'm going first. Y'all will get your turn. But now I need a crew. Give me a push.

(Chuck and Emily push Drit and the Dritmobile to exit.)

JIMMY

You're gonna break your fool neck.

MEETING MR. DIGGER

ROY

How'd y'all like them stories I brought back? Good, huh?

BARKSDALE

Not bad. But you've got an hour to go before quitting time.

(Enter Joe laughing)

JOE

Lawd, lawd, what fools these mortals be. As I came into town, I found a fella digging his own grave.

BARKSDALE

You mean ol' George. He's been working for quite awhile.

JOE

That's right ol' George. What a nut. I found him talking to some teenagers.

(Jennie, Dee, and Stacey approach Digger.)

JENNIE

Hello, sir. What are you doing?

DIGGER

Digging a grave, of course. Anybody can see that.

DEE

Whose grave, sir?

DIGGER

Mine, galldurn it. Mind your own business.

DEE

Why are you digging your own grave?

DIGGER

Ain't nobody gonna do it for me.

DEE

I thought somebody dug a grave after a person died.

DIGGER

Now who would do that? Not my family. None of them worth a toot. Except my wife, and she's dead already. Worked herself plumb to death. Spent most of her life picking cotton and killing hogs and washing and sewing and cooking and a whole lot more. I should have noticed how skinny and rundown she looked.

One morning she said she was wore out and couldn't get up. She just laid in bed getting weaker and weaker. I called the doctor, but he couldn't do nothing. Some kind of quack, I guess. Didn't forget to send the bill. She just wasted away and died.

STACEY

Is this her, sir?

(Reading.)

She was too good,
Too gentle and fair,
To dwell in this
Cold world of care.



DIGGER

My kids won't have nothing to do with me. Moved away some of 'em. The rest keep away. They blame me for every blessed thing whether I done it or not.

JENNIE

And there's nobody else?

DIGGER

Nobody and nothing. I can dig my own galldurned grave. Why should I pay someone else to do it. Now you take them folks from Oliver's. Always coming out here to conduct some funeral or other and bother me with their galldurned questions.

Speak of the devil! Here they come again. Only I ain't never seen these two. Complete strangers. I ain't gonna say nothing to 'em. I'm gonna hide me behind this tree.

(He looks offstage and shouts.)

Hey, what y'all doing? That's my grave. Go on! Get outa here!

(From offstage: "Help, help it's a hant!")

Ha! Look at 'em run! Reckon they thought I was some galldurned ghost. Yes sir, a gallddurned ghost.

DEE

I'd run away from a ghost.

JENNIE

Me too.

STACEY

Gotcha!

DIGGER

Ain't no such thing as a ghost. Ain't nothing nohow. Ain't nothing but meanness and spite.
Galldurn it!

I should have noticed how sick she was. I should have noticed.
(Digger and teenagers exit.)

BARKSDALE

Poor ol' George. He's been digging a grave most of his life.

JOE

That's for sure!

DRITMOBILE II

(Enter Drit, Chuck, and Emily. Drit has a bandage round his head and is limping. He carries pieces of the Dritmobile.)

DRIT

We come to pay for the soda pop, Mr. Barksdale. We're alive and well.

BARKSDALE

Well, Drit, you may be alive, but you don't look too well. What happened?

CHUCK

You should have seen him. He took the Dritmobile all the way to the top. He was coming straight down the hill.

EMILY

Flat out!

JIMMY

Better off to junk that contraption.

AT LAST his notes
bad off
(P.S. 500)

DRIT

No way. There's nothing wrong with the Dritmobile. It was my fault. The ride was a little rough since it don't have no shocks. The steering is quick enough. 'Course it don't have no brakes.

I misjudged the turn, swerved right and took out a tombstone. I mean the tombstone took out the Dritmobile.

EMILY

And took out Drit.

CHUCK

I thought Drit was gonna take out that tombstone with his head. Man, it was a terrible sight. The Dritmobile scattered all over the cemetery. And there sat Drit, with this big ol' gash on his head holding onto the steering wheel.

EMILY

He was bleeding like a stuck pig!

DRIT

You see, I didn't break my neck. I only broke my head. We'll get it right next time. First, the Dritmobile needs some fixing up.

BARKSDALE

Tell you what, kids. The soda pop's on me. I never in my life saw such heroes and such blamed fools all wrapped up in the same package.

CHUCK & EMILY

I get to drive next time!

DRIT

Maybe some time. Now we got work to do. Come on, let's go!

(They exit.)

ROY'S PARTY

(Enter Ora with a big bouquet.)

ORA

Hi, y'all. I've got a nice bouquet for Roy. Kate tells me it's his birthday.

ROY

My gosh, she remembered. I thought she was gonna spend the whole day nagging me.

ORA

Flowers and food, from what I hear. Gonna be a regular party.

ROY

Man O man, a party?

ORA

Oops! I think I let the cat outa the bag. I think it was supposed to be a surprise.

ROY

That's OK. What kind of food?

THE MEN

Yeah, tell us!

ORA

Don't worry, everyone is invited. Kate is going all out. She and Maxine are gonna bring it over in a few minutes.

THE MEN

What kind of food?

ORA

Nothing but the best. Let's see now There's gonna be cheese straws and broccoli squares and pickled mushrooms and fried walnuts ...

THE MEN

Fried walnuts?

ORA

Nothing but the best. And let's see, a vegetable casserole with French cut green beans and real almonds and water chestnuts. Oh, and a pineapple casserole ...

THE MEN

A pineapple casserole!

ROY

Isn't there any meat?

ORA

You boys will get all the protein you need with Maxine's famous anchovy stuffed eggs.

THE MEN

Where's the beef?

ORA

We knew you'd want some meat, so we made a nice bowl of curried chicken salad ...

THE MEN

Good lord! Chicken salad!

ORA

I'm sorry I gave you all this wonderful news in advance. So I want you to act surprised and use good manners and be grateful for this delicious food. Kate and Maxine worked so hard.

THE MEN

Aw, come on!

ORA

Be grateful!

THE MEN

All right. Yes, Ma'am. We'll try.

ORA

Here they come now.

(Kate and Maxine and others enter singing "Southern Cooking." Among the group are Jean and Stanley riding their tractor.)

KATE

I am so sorry. I thought I ordered a pineapple casserole. Instead I got butter beans and green beans with bacon. I apologize.

THE MEN

Mmm ... That quite all right.

MAXINE

I'm sorry, I did my best with those anchovy stuffed eggs. But they just didn't turn out. I had to bring deer meat with grits and onions. I am so sorry.

THE MEN

Mmm ... Don't be sorry.

ORA

I apologize too. Seems I gave you boys wrong information. I thought there was going to be curried chicken salad. But instead there's fried chicken and gravy and mashed potatoes. I am so sorry.

THE MEN

Don't be sorry. Mmm ...

ORA

And I must apologize for being so forgetful. I totally forgot we're having sweet potato pie!

ALL

Sweet potato pie! Mmm ... Mmm ...

(Jennie and Dee bring in a birthday cake. "Southern Cooking" transitions to the birthday song and "Celebration." Roy makes an effort to blow out the candles. Cries of "speech, speech." Roy stands hand in hand with Kate.)

ROY

I want to thank y'all for the happiest day of life. I'm happier now than all the times I outsmarted that know-it-all Judge Boatman. I'm happier than all the times I stood down on Front Street and watched the trains come through. I'm happier than I ever was eating hot roasted peanuts with good ol' Lemon. Or sitting at the picture show watching Lash Larue. I'm happier than I ever was listening to Grandpa's lies and getting good advice from Mr. Fred Watts and catching all the stories flying all over Winona and Montgomery County. I'm happier than all the times I've stood around and listened to the great music of John Hurt. I'm just plain happy.

And you know why I'm happy. I got a belly full of good food, and a lot of good friends. I got the best job in the world and the best boss in the world. Thank you, Barksdale. And I know if I keep plugging away, I'm gonna get that promotion. And I think Putt's gonna forgive me and let me change his oil again. And I'm gonna keep washing cars till I get it right. And I'm gonna keep listening for stories. I'm gonna listen to the voices of the best folks in the world.

And most of all I'm happy 'cause – well, I'm happy 'cause I got Kate. And I guess she's got me. She's stuck with me and sticking by me. I'm a lucky guy. Thank you, Kate. I'm just happy.

(They embrace and kiss. All applaud. Transition to finale and "Amazing Grace.")

And most of all I'm